

CaaS RFI Questions & Answers

1. **General:** Are baseline network diagrams for the supported sites current and available to offerors during performance (VLANs, security zones, uplinks? Are there any known hard blockers to migration (unsupported OS versions, legacy HBA constraints, specialized drivers, encryption key dependencies)?
 - Detailed network topology diagrams will not be provided during the solicitation phase. Upon award, the Government will provide the necessary infrastructure and environmental details required for the selected contractor to successfully install and integrate their solution. The PWS requires a bare-metal hardware solution; the Government is solely responsible for the operating systems, applications, and all other aspects of the software stack. The Government has not identified any blockers in its environment that would prevent the integration of a compliant hardware solution.
2. **Pricing:** Is the government requesting ROM pricing expressed as per-unit pricing per hardware type (example: per server, per switch, per storage device) or, expressed in some other method?
 - Per Section 8.0 of the PWS, offerors shall propose all-inclusive, fixed prices on a per-unit basis for each hardware category.
3. **PWS Supported Performance Locations:** Can the government confirm the supported performance locations are limited to Marine Corps Information Technology Center (MCITC), Kansas City, MO, and Marine Corps Base Quantico, VA?
 - Confirmed. Per Section 8.0.8 of the PWS, the places of performance are the Marine Corps Information Technology Center (MCITC) in Kansas City, MO, and Newlin Hall aboard Marine Corps Base Quantico, VA.
4. **17.0 Training and Knowledge Transfer:** does the government anticipate a formalized training plan with performance metrics, or is the expectation more aligned to one-on-one deskside knowledge transfer tasks?
 - The intent of Section 17.0 is to address the informal knowledge transfer that is considered an intrinsic part of the CaaS hardware delivery. For example, during hardware installation, the contractor's personnel are expected to be able to answer Government questions about the specific hardware being installed. This ancillary support is considered part of the all-inclusive, per-unit hardware price.
 - This is distinct from the purchasable "Engineering and Technical Support Services" line items. Any requirement for formal, project-based professional services labor, such as data migration planning, application integration, or customized operational training, would be scoped and procured separately under those contract provisions. Offerors must not bundle costs for such professional services into their CaaS hardware pricing.
5. **PWS 5.1.1 LUN:** Is the "≥50TB LUN/NVMe namespace" requirement intended as a single volume requirement?
 - Yes. The requirement detailed in PWS Section 5.1.1 means the proposed solution must have the capability to provision a single, contiguous logical volume (LUN or NVMe namespace) of at least 50TB to a single host.

1. Technical architecture and interoperability

- Please confirm whether the Government prefers a single-OEM CaaS catalog (for storage/compute/network) or is open to a multi-OEM approach as long as interoperability requirements are met.
 - The Government's incumbent infrastructure is based on a multi-OEM architecture. While offerors may propose any solution—single or multi-OEM—that meets all PWS requirements, any proposed solution must integrate seamlessly into the existing environment. Offerors proposing solutions that differ from the Government's preferred technical components must provide specific evidence in their proposal demonstrating that their "or equal" submissions meet the salient characteristics required for interoperability with the Government's existing management tools, security monitoring, and automation scripts. The burden of proof for "equality" rests solely on the offeror.
- Are there incumbent storage, compute, and SAN/NAS platforms (by vendor and family) that the Government expects the CaaS capacity to integrate with for at least the first option period?

- Networking (Cisco or Equal): Any proposed solution must provide a command-line interface (CLI) and REST API that are syntactically and functionally equivalent to Cisco NX-OS and Cisco IOS-XE, and supports the Cisco Discovery Protocol (CDP) for network discovery.
- Storage (NetApp or Equal): Any proposed solution must support native, asynchronous, block-level replication that is protocol-compatible with the existing NetApp SnapMirror services used for disaster recovery. The management API must have feature parity with the ONTAP REST API.

For offeror's situational awareness, the Government's incumbent storage environment is architected using NetApp Storage Virtual Machines (SVMs) to organize and serve data. Government personnel will be solely responsible for executing the migration of all workloads from this incumbent environment to the new solution.

Therefore, the offeror's proposal must identify and describe the specific features, native software tools, and documented procedures included with their proposed solution that will enable Government personnel to perform a minimally disruptive migration. The description must address how these tools facilitate the migration of all logical data components—including, but not limited to, LUNs, NFS/SMB file shares, and their associated access permissions and configurations—from the incumbent platform to the offeror's proposed platform.

- Application Delivery (F5 or Equal): Any proposed solution must provide a traffic scripting capability with functional and syntactic parity to F5's iRules for managing complex application traffic.
 - Compute (Dell or Equal): Any proposed solution must provide a "lights-out" remote management interface with a REST API that is functionally equivalent to the Dell iDRAC9 API for automated server provisioning and monitoring.
- For specialty / AI tiers, does the Government have a preferred accelerator ecosystem (e.g., specific NVIDIA SKUs, NIC vendors, or InfiniBand vs. Ethernet) or should industry propose best-value options meeting the stated requirements?
 - The Government has no preferred accelerator ecosystem. Offerors should propose a solution that meets the performance requirements outlined in the PWS and represents the best value to the Government.

2. Catalog, CLINs, and pricing

- How many distinct capacity SKUs (servers, storage tiers, SAN switches, network devices) does the Government anticipate needing in the initial catalog, and will there be a structured process for adding/removing SKUs during performance?
 - The Government has not pre-defined a number of SKUs. The offeror's proposal must define the initial catalog by proposing specific solutions and corresponding per-unit prices for each hardware category described in the PWS.
- Does the Government intend to weight evaluation more heavily toward lowest unit rate, breadth of catalog (capacity range), or lifecycle value (SLA strength, OEM support tiers, refresh strategy)?
 - The award will be made using a best-value tradeoff under Simplified Acquisition Procedures, allowing the Government to consider technical merit, past performance, and price in determining the Firm Fixed Price solution that offers the greatest overall value.
- Can the Government clarify expectations for documenting “verifiable industry benchmarks” when introducing new capacity types post-award (e.g., is GSA pricing sufficient or are additional commercial comparables desired)?
 - This will depend on the structure of the type of acquisition that we decision to move forward with – at this time this will be a Firm Fixed Price requirement, under Simplified Acquisition Procedures.

3. Operational model and SLAs

- For the 40-business-day delivery SLA for new hardware and 20-business-day SLA for add-on capacity, what typical lead times or surge scenarios does the Government forecast, and are there mission-critical use cases that would justify accelerated tiers?
 - The Government has no specific forecast data to provide regarding surge scenarios. The SLAs stated in the PWS are the Government's firm requirements. Offerors' proposals must address their capability and strategy for meeting these delivery timelines. The PWS does not currently define requirements for accelerated delivery tiers.
- How does the Government envision monitoring and confirming “degraded capacity” conditions that would justify billing suspension, and will there be a standard joint validation process for those determinations?
 - The process for billing suspension is specifically intended as a remedy for inoperable hardware that is not remediated in a timely manner. The process begins when the Government identifies a faulty component and notifies the contractor's personnel. The contractor is then responsible for opening a trouble ticket, which initiates the Service Level Agreement (SLA) clock for remediation as defined in PWS Section 10.0.
 - Billing suspension is not applicable during the initial troubleshooting and repair period, provided the contractor is adhering to the PWS-defined SLAs. It is an escalation measure. Should the contractor fail to repair or replace the inoperable hardware within the required SLA timeframe, the Government's Contracting Officer's Representative (COR) will make the official determination that an SLA breach has occurred. Upon such a determination, the Government reserves the right to suspend billing for the non-functional capacity, retroactive to the date of the initial trouble ticket, until the hardware is restored to full operational status.

4. Security, data handling, and OEM support

- The PWS prohibits cloud-connected telemetry agents and remote diagnostic utilities that transmit data off-prem; can the Government clarify acceptable methods for OEM health monitoring and log transfer (e.g., manual log upload, air-gapped tools)?
 - Any proposed solution must be capable of being fully functional and supportable while operating in a disconnected mode, without reliance on automated, off-premise "call home" or cloud-based telemetry. The Government reserves the right to review and sanitize any data deemed necessary for security purposes prior to transmission off-premise. This is the baseline security requirement.
 - The Government's security policies and the need to comply with applicable Security Technical Implementation Guides (STIGs) will dictate whether any specific automated diagnostic feature can be enabled. The Government reserves the right to approve or deny the use of such features on a case-by-case basis. Therefore, the standard and expected method for providing diagnostic data to an off-site OEM is via manual collection of logs by Government personnel. These logs would then be transferred using Government-approved secure mechanisms. Offerors must confirm in their proposals that their solution fully supports this manual, air-gapped support model.
- Are there any anticipated classified workloads or locations that would trigger a DD254 during the base or option years, and if so, what classification level and facility clearance will likely be required?
 - All work described in the current PWS is at the Unclassified level. A DD Form 254, Contract Security Classification Specification, is not anticipated to be issued at the time of award. Should a requirement for classified work emerge, it will be addressed via a contract modification.

5. Programmatic and vehicles

- Beyond the two named locations, does the Government anticipate future expansion of the CaaS footprint (e.g., additional Marine Corps sites or tactical locations) during the option periods?
 - The defined scope of the PWS is limited to the two named locations. While the Government has no planned requirements for expansion at this time, it reserves the right to add future performance locations via contract modification if a need arises.
1. Are there any unique aspects to your Capacity as a Service that you are looking for? i.e. Cancel without penalty or other?
 2. Are you looking for an existing Data Center with existing and specific security requirements?
 - To clarify the core requirement of the PWS: The Government is seeking to acquire new, contractor-owned and maintained hardware to be placed within two existing, Government-owned data center locations (MCITC, Kansas City, MO, and MCB Quantico, VA). This is not a requirement for a colocation facility, nor is the Government migrating data to a contractor-owned site.
 3. Are you looking to procure new hardware to place in one or more existing data center locations?
 - To clarify the core requirement of the PWS: The Government is seeking to acquire new, contractor-owned and maintained hardware to be placed within two existing, Government-owned data center locations (MCITC, Kansas City, MO, and MCB Quantico, VA). This is not a requirement for a colocation facility, nor is the Government migrating data to a contractor-owned site.

4. Or are you looking to migrate existing data to a new data center / co – lo where you do not own the actual hardware?
 - To clarify the core requirement of the PWS: The Government is seeking to acquire new, contractor-owned and maintained hardware to be placed within two existing, Government-owned data center locations (MCITC, Kansas City, MO, and MCB Quantico, VA). This is not a requirement for a colocation facility, nor is the Government migrating data to a contractor-owned site
5. Have you done an Application Portfolio Analysis to learn more about existing workloads and data sets?
 - The management of the Government's application portfolio is a Government responsibility and is not within the scope of this PWS. The contractor's responsibility is to provide hardware capacity that meets the technical specifications defined in the PWS when a Task Order is issued.
6. Do you have any Back up or Disaster Recovery Requirements?
 - The Government is responsible for its own backup and disaster recovery strategy. The PWS requires that the contractor's proposed storage solution provide features that can support this strategy, such as the ability to interoperate with the Government's existing NetApp SnapMirror replication services.
7. Do you have a sense of what percentage of data growth year over year might be?
 - The Government has not provided a forecast for data growth or usage surges.
8. Is there an expectation of data surges or significant flex up / flex down times during the contract period?
 - The Government has not provided a forecast for data growth or usage surges.
9. Do you have an estimated duration to migrate data?
 - Data migration is a Government responsibility. Therefore, migration timelines are not relevant to the contractor's scope of work under this PWS.
10. Could you clarify the type of environment involved? For example, is it classified, top secret, or a dark site? This information will help us determine whether telemetry can be extracted from the site.
 - All work described in the current PWS is at the Unclassified level, and the facilities are not considered dark sites. However, all hardware must be compliant with Government security policies and applicable STIGs. Automated, off-premise telemetry is prohibited unless explicitly approved by the Government on a case-by-case basis.
11. Would you consider moving from traditional FC SAN to Ethernet NVMe/TCP network architecture?
 - The Government's incumbent storage network is a converged Fibre Channel over Ethernet (FCoE) fabric. A dedicated, traditional Fibre Channel (FC) SAN is not in use and is not a requirement.
 - The Government's primary technical requirement is ensuring the proposed new solution can integrate with the existing Ethernet infrastructure to allow for a host-based data migration to be performed by Government personnel.
 - Therefore, offerors may propose any modern, Ethernet-based block storage solution. The proposal must confirm it can coexist on the same physical network as the incumbent FCoE system. Compliant solutions would include, but are not limited to, those that natively support FCoE, iSCSI, or NVMe/TCP. The offeror must clearly state which protocol(s) their solution utilizes.
12. When does Government anticipate to release an RFP/RFQ for this effort?
 - 30 -60 days

13. In regards of delivery of equipment, what might the potential delivery schedule look like for this effort?
- The required delivery schedule is explicitly defined in Section 10.0, Service Level Agreements (SLAs), of the Performance Work Statement.
14. Does Government possess any specific Logistics Support Requirements (LSR) for this effort, and if so what are they?
- All logistics and support requirements are contained within the PWS. This includes, but is not limited to, requirements for delivery, installation, maintenance, and end-of-service de-installation.
15. Does Government require any asset tagging for this effort?
- Yes. All contractor-owned hardware placed in Government facilities must be tagged for inventory purposes in accordance with Government-provided direction at the time of installation.